Squatters Migrate Across Australia

In the early 19th century, freed convicts, soldiers and others transformed the wild land given to them by the government into thriving farms. The British people heard about the great prospects to be had in Australia, which resulted in more ships sailing out from Britain. Known as squatters, these British people made their way deeper into the lands of the Aborigines while looking for land of their own and fresh water for their livestock.

White settlement in Australia was relatively small in the first three decades after the arrival of the First Fleet because the Napoleonic Wars had delayed transportation. By 1810, the white population of New South Wales had increased to 12,000. The population was mostly made up of convicts and military personnel with a few lawyers, clergymen and doctors. Over the next seven decades, Australia's non-Indigenous population increased substantially to reach 406,000 in 1850. On the eve of the gold rush, many migrants landed in Australia and increased the population to 1,648,000 in 1870. The next three decades witnessed further demographic growth with a huge surge in immigration. The population became 3,770,000 at the time of Federation in 1901 when Australia officially became a nation. Some 78% had been born in Australia, 18% in the British Isles, 2% in other European countries and less than 2% in Asian or Pacific countries.

Between 1831 and 1900, half of the 1.47 million migrants to Australia had passages subsidized by the British government. They were recruited under the systematic colonization policies of Edward Gibbon Wakefield whereby revenue from Australian sales was used to subsidize passages on government-sponsored ships. However, other schemes also existed whereby immigrants were selected and recruited. The great majority of settlers in Australia came from British or Irish backgrounds. For shorthand purposes, it is helpful to refer to them as Anglo-Celtic because Britain and Ireland were politically joined as part of the United Kingdom. There were notable differences between the British and Irish immigrants in their religious allegiances. Most Irish immigrants were Catholic, many English settlers were Anglican and many Scots were Presbyterian. All of these groups held widely diverse views about education, culture, and politics. Therefore, it